

Mock Interview — rehearse the real back-and-forth

The interview isn't a speech, it's a conversation: they ask, you answer, **they push back**, you respond. That follow-up is where marks are won or lost — so practise being pushed. Below are 5 full rounds (Q1 + Q2 + Q3, like the real draw) plus the probes a tutor will actually throw at you.

How to run a round (do this for real)

1. **Set a 12-minute timer. No notes. Stand up. Talk OUT LOUD** (record on your phone if you can — listening back is brutal and brilliant).
2. Answer Q1, then Q2, then Q3. ~3-4 min each.
3. After each answer, **read the follow-up probes and answer those too, cold**. This is the bit that matters.
4. **Only then** open `A-question-bank.md` to compare. Don't read it first — answering cold is the whole exercise.
5. Score yourself with the checklist at the bottom. The questions you fumbled are your revision list.

The golden habit for every single answer: **take a position** → **give one reason** → **name the best objection** → **say why you still hold your view** → **one example**. If you do that, you're scoring even when you're unsure.

ROUND 1

- **Q1 (wks 9-11):** Are nuclear weapons *mala in se* — evil in themselves?
 - *Probes:* "If a tiny tactical nuke could hit only combatants at sea, would you still say so?" · "Is the wrong the radiation, or the scale of indiscriminate killing?" · "Could a consequentialist ever agree something is evil-in-itself?"
- **Q2 (wks 1-8):** Is the realist right that morality is simply irrelevant to war?
 - *Probes:* "Aren't states that fight morally just going to lose?" · "Isn't 'a state should protect its people' already a moral claim?" · "Descriptive or prescriptive realism — which are you rejecting?"
- **Q3 (synthesis):** Does the double-effect reasoning that excuses some civilian deaths (W8) also excuse drone collateral damage (W10)?
 - *Probes:* "Where's the line between foreseen and intended for a drone strike?" · "Do signature strikes pass or fail double effect?" · "Isn't 'didn't intend it' too convenient once the bodies pile up?"

ROUND 2

- **Q1:** Explain Sparrow's responsibility-gap argument. Is it convincing?
 - *Probes:* "Why can't we just blame the commander who deployed it?" · "If we accept the gap, does that ban *all* autonomy, or just lethal autonomy?" · "Is a responsibility gap really worse than a human who's never caught?"
- **Q2:** What makes a person a legitimate target — being a threat, being responsible, or wearing a uniform?
 - *Probes:* "Is a sleeping soldier a legitimate target? Why?" · "What about a munitions-factory worker?" · "If it's responsibility, do unjust-side soldiers still have a right to kill?" (McMahan)
- **Q3:** Can Walzer's moral equality of combatants survive autonomous weapons (W11)?
 - *Probes:* "Who is the robot's 'moral equal' on the battlefield?" · "Does McMahan's liability view handle robots better or worse?"

ROUND 3

- **Q1:** Is targeted killing more like an act of war or more like extrajudicial execution?
 - *Probes:* "What turns it from one into the other?" · "What exactly is wrong with a signature strike?" · "If it's 'war', does the target get any protection at all?"
- **Q2:** Define terrorism. Is it *always* morally worse than conventional war?
 - *Probes:* "Can a state be a terrorist?" · "If war also kills innocents, why is terrorism special?" (Held) · "Is it the target, the intention, or the fear that makes it terrorism?"
- **Q3:** Is nuclear deterrence (W9) defensible on the same grounds a realist (W3) defends war?
 - *Probes:* "Is deterrence a moral argument or just a survival argument?" · "If it 'works', does that settle it?" · "What if it doesn't actually work?" (Ward Wilson)

ROUND 4

- **Q1:** Arkin says robots could be *more* humane than soldiers. Should we build them if they'd kill fewer civilians?
 - *Probes:* "If they demonstrably kill fewer civilians, isn't refusing them the immoral choice?" · "What does Sparrow say to that?" · "Is 'fewer deaths' the only thing that matters here?"
- **Q2:** Is national self-defence morally analogous to individual self-defence?
 - *Probes:* "What exactly is a country defending — lives, or institutions?" · "Would a bloodless invasion justify killing?" (Rodin) · "Does the analogy do more work than it can bear?"
- **Q3:** Does Sparrow's "robots and respect" argument (W11) also condemn riskless drone killing (W10)?
 - *Probes:* "Does war need mutual risk to keep its moral character?" · "Isn't protecting your own troops just good?" · "Is being killed from a trailer a failure of respect too?"

ROUND 5 — exam-day simulation (the hardest set)

- **Q1:** Can the *threat* of nuclear retaliation be moral even if actually *using* the weapon would not be?
 - *Probes:* "Does sincere deterrence require intending mass murder?" · "Is intending a wrong you never commit still a wrong?" · "Is a bluff morally cleaner — and would it even work?"
 - **Q2:** What is the strongest version of pacifism, and what is the best objection to it?
 - *Probes:* "Absolute or contingent pacifism — which is stronger?" · "Doesn't calling all killing 'murder' erase the combatant/innocent line?" (Anscombe) · "Can pacifism actually *licence* atrocity?"
 - **Q3:** Pick one principle — distinction, proportionality, or *mala in se* — and show how it plays out in **two** of nuclear / drones / robots.
 - *Probes:* "Which is the harder case for that principle, and why?" · "Does the principle break, bend, or hold?" · "So what's your overall view?"
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The examiner's universal probe bank (they can append any of these to ANYTHING)

Rehearse a calm one-line response to each — these are the same five questions in disguise:

- "*Is that a consequentialist or a deontological reason?*" → name it, own it.
- "*What's the strongest objection to your own view?*" → give a real one; conceding it scores.
- "*Can you give me a concrete example?*" → have one real case per topic ready.
- "*Where exactly is the line?*" → point to it, then name the case just on the other side.
- "*Is that a going-to-war or a how-you-fight question?*" → ad bellum vs in bello; don't mix them.
- "*So, on balance, what do you actually think?*" → never dodge this. Land the plane.

Self-score after each round (tick honestly)

For each answer, did you:

- ☐ **Take a clear position?** (not "it depends")
- ☐ **Give at least one real reason?**
- ☐ **Name the strongest objection** — and reply to it?
- ☐ **Stay clear and plain** (a friend could follow you)?
- ☐ **Use the master key** (outcomes vs rules) somewhere?
- ☐ **Survive the follow-up probes** without collapsing?

6/6 across all three questions = you're ready. Anything you missed = tonight's revision. Do a fresh round tomorrow.

Answers to compare against live in `A-question-bank.md`. The reasoning, not the wording, is what you're checking.